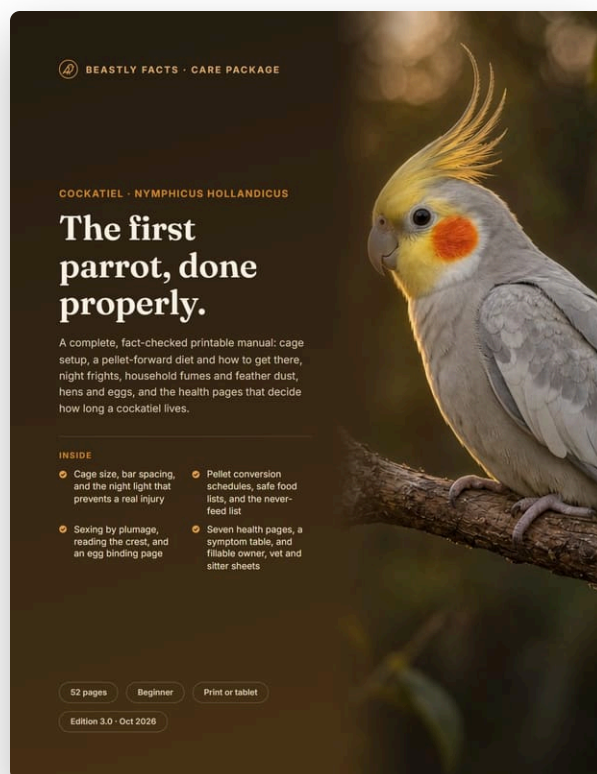


FREE SAMPLE

Cockatiel Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 52-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Species, Colors, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 52 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 47 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/cockatiel/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free cockatiel care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/cockatiel/, and stays free.

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) and feet (ft), with centimeters (cm) beside them. A cockatiel and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't bought a bird yet

Read the profile and housing pages, 4 to 11, before buying anything. Two decisions cost the most to undo: the cage on page 6, which people buy small and then replace, and whether you bring home one cockatiel or two on page 18. Settle both, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 38 to buy once instead of twice.

If your cockatiel is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist in the print list below, then read page 13 if the bird is on a seed mix: diet drives most of the health problems on the health pages, and the change takes days to months, so starting it today matters more than finishing this book first. Then read page 8, because a night light costs almost nothing and prevents the injury this species is known for. If anything looks wrong, go straight to Red Flags on page 29.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 36: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 44: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 37: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 45: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 41: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 46: Equipment & Vet Log |
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WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

The cockatiel is sold as the easy, gentle first parrot, and much of that is true. A lot of the advice in circulation is not: a seed bowl, a tall narrow cage bought for its looks, and a room left pitch dark all night are still normal advice somewhere, and all three shorten a cockatiel's life or injure it. Every figure here is cross-checked against the veterinary and published sources listed on page 50.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is a vet call, not a page in this book, and a cockatiel hides illness until it is far along. Find an avian vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card.

SECTION 01 • PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Nymphicus hollandicus</i> . The smallest member of the cockatoo family, and the only species in its genus.
Adult size	12 to 13 in (30 to 33 cm) including the tail; 80 to 125 g, about 90 g on average
Captive lifespan	12 to 15 years typically, with up to about 25 reported; the longevity record is 35 years
Native range	Open grassland, scrubland and lightly wooded country across Australia, in nomadic flocks that follow water and seeding grasses
Diet type	Grass seeds, grains, berries and insects in the wild; in captivity 75 to 80% pellets, with vegetables and a little fruit (page 12)
Cage, one bird	About 20×20×30 in (51×51×76 cm) as the minimum; 24×24×30 in (61×61×76 cm) for easier movement. Wider beats taller.
Bar spacing	Half an inch (1.3 cm) or smaller
Room temperature	About 70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C), with no drafts and no direct sun on the cage
Darkness and light	10 to 12 hours of quiet, dark sleep every night, with a cover or a small night light against night frights. Daylight: a bright room on the normal day length; a bird-safe full-spectrum lamp on the same timer if the room is dim, because window glass blocks the useful part of sunlight. Direct sun under 20 minutes, with shade it can reach.
Sexing	By plumage in a standard gray adult over 6 months old; most color varieties need a DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid) test (page 25)
Handling difficulty	Beginner, built on trust over 7 to 14 days of settling and short sessions
Conservation status	Least Concern, the lowest-risk grade on the global list of threatened species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$370 to \$765 for a complete starter setup, bird included (\$75 to \$250 of it, depending on the color). The cage is often the biggest single line, more than the bird. Every line is on page 38.

Ongoing

About \$180 to \$360 a year for food, toy replacement and cage upkeep, \$15 to \$30 a month. Avian vet exams come on top, at least once a year.

THE LINE ITEM PEOPLE LEAVE OUT

Avian vets are a specialized field, harder to find and often pricier than a general small-animal clinic. Pet insurance for birds is uncommon, and reproductive emergencies like egg binding arrive with no warning. Set money aside for them from the start.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Cockatiels were the first parrot species to be widely bred in captivity, and remain among the most popular pet birds in the world.
- Males especially learn whistled tunes and will repeat them for hours, and many pick up short phrases too.
- Australia bars the export of its native birds, so every cockatiel kept anywhere else descends from stock that was already outside the country.

The species, colors, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

A small cockatoo

The cockatiel is *Nymphicus hollandicus*, the smallest member of the cockatoo family and endemic to Australia. In the wild it lives in open country and lightly wooded areas across the continent, moving with the water and with whichever grasses are seeding. Like the larger cockatoos it carries a movable crest and produces powder down, a fine feather dust that films the furniture near the cage (page 9). It was the first parrot widely bred in captivity, prized for its gentle temperament, whistling and trainability.

Colors

The normal gray, with a yellow face and orange cheek patches, is the closest color to the wild bird and is usually the cheapest, because it needs no selective breeding to produce. Every other color carries a premium. Four mutations underpin nearly every variety on sale: pied, which appeared in California in 1949, lutino in 1958, cinnamon during the 1950s, and pearl in 1967. Color matters for one practical reason: the plumage sexing method works on the normal gray and fails on most of the rest (page 25). The care in this package applies to every color.

Size and age

Length	12 to 13 in (30 to 33 cm) including the long tail
Weight	80 to 125 g, about 90 g on average. Your own bird's settled weight matters more than the range (page 16).
Weaning	Around 42 to 52 days old. Most pet cockatiels are bought already weaned onto solid food.
Maturity	6 to 12 months. Until about 6 months every young cockatiel is colored like a hen.

Lifespan

12 to 15 years is typical, a well-kept bird can reach about 25, and the longevity record is 35 years for one exceptional bird. Budget for the long end. A cockatiel bought for a 10-year-old can still be on its perch when that child finishes college, and the cage, the avian vet and the daily routine have to last all of those years.

Whistling and noise

Cockatiels are whistlers far more than talkers. They learn and repeat whole melodies, and some pick up a few words, but whistling is the real strength, and males are the ones known for it. Most of the day is whistling and chatter at a volume most households barely register. The exception is a sharp contact call or the well-known wolf whistle, which cuts through a quiet room in short bursts, especially during a hormonal phase. In an apartment with thin walls, weigh that before you buy.

A PREY BIRD FIRST

Wild cockatiels live in flocks where a predator picks off the bird that looks weakest. That one fact explains three things in this book: the bird wants company, it hides illness until it cannot, and a sudden movement in the dark sends it into a panic.